

Viral Content Guide

Based on SUCCESS Model + Social Diffusion Principles

1. Simple

Focus on one core memorable idea (max 1–3).

Highlight a single defining trait.

Use strong analogies (e.g., 'It's like X, but with Y').

Create a curiosity gap — simple but slightly incomplete.

Ask: If someone remembers one thing, what is it?

2. Unexpected

Break established patterns to capture attention.

Surprise grabs attention; mystery sustains it.

Create a curiosity gap that can only be resolved by continuing.

Avoid repeating the same surprise format — novelty fades.

3. Concrete

Show, don't tell.

Use vivid sensory detail people can visualise.

Replace abstract terms with tangible imagery.

Ask: Can I see it? If not, make it more concrete.

4. Credible

Raw statistics alone are weak — add meaningful comparisons.

Anchor numbers to physical equivalents.

Use demonstrations or testable claims.

Encourage audiences to verify or test themselves.

5. Emotional Core

Turn abstract ideas into human impact.

Use the 3 Whys to uncover fundamental motivation.

Anchor ideas to basic human needs (safety, belonging, progress, identity, hope).

High-arousal emotions drive sharing (anger, anxiety, awe, excitement).

Low-arousal emotions reduce sharing (contentment, mild sadness).

6. Word of Mouth (STEPPS)

Social Currency: Make people feel smart, special, or insiders.

Triggers: Link your message to everyday cues.

Emotion: Activate high-arousal feelings.

Public: Make private behaviour visible.

Practical Value: Share useful, actionable advice.

Stories: Embed the message inside narrative.

7. Social Influence

People rely on social proof when uncertain.

Normative influence: we conform to fit in or avoid exclusion.

Identity signalling: consumption reflects who we are.

Functional decisions favour conformity; symbolic decisions favour divergence.

8. Network Structure

Networks consist of nodes (people) and ties (connections).

Homophily: people connect with similar others.

Bridges between clusters enable wider diffusion.

Identical content performs differently depending on structure.

9. Network Effects

Value increases as more people adopt.

Adoption is slow at first, then accelerates at critical mass.

Position in a network can matter more than popularity.

Bridges are necessary to move influence between groups.

10. Strong vs Weak Ties

Strong ties: frequent interaction, high trust, redundant information.

Weak ties: connect different groups, provide novel information.

Weak ties are critical for spreading ideas across clusters.

Design content that weak ties feel comfortable sharing publicly.

11. Sprinkler vs Waterfall Strategy

Sprinkler: Spread resources widely for simple contagions (one exposure needed).

Waterfall: Concentrate resources for complex contagions (multiple exposures needed).

The more costly or risky the behaviour, the more reinforcement required.